Twelve Small Things to Notice About Your Wife's Day Before New Caregivers Arrive

The everyday habits you stopped seeing years ago, and what to write down about each.

After enough years together, you stop seeing the routine: which cup, which chair, the radio on before breakfast. New caregivers won't know any of it unless someone writes it down. This guide names twelve everyday things worth noticing this week and, for each, what to write.

Notice and record. Don't interpret. None of these is a symptom and this isn't a health check. It's a way of catching the habits that make a day hers. Wherever you can, ask her instead of guessing, and write her answer in her words. Most of the areas follow the headings of a form the Alzheimer's Association gives families, called Personal Facts and Insights. We borrowed the headings because they cover an ordinary day well, not because of anything about your wife's health. The wording about what to write down is ours.

First thing in the morning

1 When she wakes, and how [1]

NOTICE The time she usually wakes, whether she likes to be woken or left to it, and how long before she wants company.

WRITE DOWN Her usual waking time and what the first half hour looks like.

2 The first drink [1]

NOTICE What she has before anything else, how she takes it, and the cup it goes in.

WRITE DOWN The drink, the way she'd ask for it herself, down to the cup.

3 The order of the morning [1]

NOTICE What comes first and what follows: washing, dressing, breakfast, the radio, the paper. And anything she won't start the day without.

WRITE DOWN The order, as a short list.

Meals

4 What she eats, and when [1]

NOTICE Her usual times for meals, what she chooses most days, the snack she goes looking for.

WRITE DOWN Meal times and favorites, in her terms.

5 What she turns down [1]

NOTICE The foods she has never liked, and the ones she'll eat only a certain way.

WRITE DOWN Her dislikes, as dislikes. Anything a clinician has told you about allergies or diet goes on a separate list, with who said it.

6 How she likes to eat

NOTICE At the table or in her chair, with company or with the television, the hot drink during the meal or after it.

WRITE DOWN Where, and with whom, she usually eats.

During the day

7 What she chooses to do [1]

NOTICE What she picks up when nobody has suggested anything: the crossword, the garden, a program, the telephone.

WRITE DOWN The activities she chooses, and any help she'd want in order to keep doing them. Whether she does them stays up to her.

8 Who she looks forward to [1]

NOTICE Who calls, who visits, whose name comes up. Whether she'd rather have one or two people or a full room.

WRITE DOWN The names, how each person is connected to her, and when they're usually in touch.

How people talk with her

9 What she's called [1]

NOTICE The name she answers to and the one she uses for herself, and any pet names she dislikes from people she doesn't know.

WRITE DOWN The name she wants new caregivers to use. Ask her. Don't guess.

10 How conversation goes best [1] [2]

NOTICE Whether she likes to chat or likes quiet, whether she wants a moment before she answers, whether she'd rather have things written down.

WRITE DOWN What works for her, in one line she'd agree with.

Evenings and unfamiliar places

11 Winding down [1]

NOTICE When she starts getting ready for bed, what she does last, how she likes the lights and the door, whether she naps in the day.

WRITE DOWN Her bedtime and the routine that leads up to it.

12 What helps somewhere new [1]

NOTICE What she does in a waiting room, a hotel or someone else's house: what she brings with her, where she likes to sit, what she asks for.

WRITE DOWN What she finds calming and what she finds irritating, in plain words. Better still, ask her what helps.

What goes to her clinician instead

This list is about habits and preferences. If, while you're paying attention, you see something about her health that is new or that concerns you, tell her doctor or nurse. It isn't a line for this page. The same goes for allergies and for anything a clinician has told you about what she eats or drinks: keep those on their own list, and ask the care team about any you can't place.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say what any habit means, whether a routine can be kept in the new setting, or what care she needs. It helps you see her day clearly enough to describe it.

Ready for the next step?

You've noticed twelve parts of her day and written them down. The care interview asks about the rest: her preferences across every part of the day, her care needs and the support around her. It turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Alzheimer's Association, Personal Facts and Insights (form)
2. The Conversation Project (Institute for Healthcare Improvement) and Ariadne Labs, What Matters to Me: A Workbook for Better Health Care